

ACT III: THE RIPPER

CHAPTER 18: THE MACHINE

****LOCATION: TVA OUTPOST (VOID SECTOR)****

The outpost didn't belong here.

In the Void, everything was organic in its decay. Rust was a fungus; rot was a smell. But the TVA outpost was a blister of sterility. It was white plastic and orange glass, slammed into the grey bedrock of the wasteland like a syringe into a bruise.

We crouched on a ridge, looking down.

"It's quiet," Logan said.

"It's too quiet," I added. "It's 'we blew the budget on the final fight so we can't afford extras' quiet."

The wind shifted.

It hit me then. The smell.

It wasn't just ozone. It was the smell of **un-happening**.

Have you ever smelled a lightning strike? It tastes like copper and burnt hair. Now imagine that lightning strike is hitting history itself. It smelled like the library of Alexandria burning. It smelled like your first pet dying. It smelled like every mistake you ever made, cooked down into a gas.

"The Time Ripper," I whispered.

"What?"

"That hum. Can you feel it?"

Logan nodded. He touched his chest.

"It feels like..." he struggled for the word. "Like I'm being erased."

"It's vibrating the atoms," I said. "It's unzipping the DNA of the universe."

We moved closer.

The ground around the outpost was glassed. Smooth. Obsidian. The heat from the Ripper's exhaust vents had turned the sand into a mirror.

We walked on our reflections. Two distorted monsters approaching the castle.

"How do we get in?" Logan asked.

"We knock," I said. "And by knock, I mean we drive a Honda Odyssey through the front door."

"We don't have the Odyssey anymore."

"Right. We wrecked it. Okay. Plan B. We use the element of surprise."

"Which is?"

"We walk in the front door and look like we belong."

"You're wearing a red spandex suit covered in blood and dog hair," Logan noted. "You don't belong anywhere."

"Ouch. Fair. But hurtful."

Suddenly, the ground shook.

THRUM.

A beam of purple light shot up from the center of the outpost. It pierced the clouds. Alioth roared—a sound like a thousand tornadoes screaming in unison.

"They're turning it on," Logan said.

"Paradox is accelerating the timeline," I realized. "He's not waiting for the Anchor to decay. He's pulling the plug."

I drew my katanas.

"Okay, peanut. No more jokes. No more bits."

I looked at him.

"We stop this. Or we die."

Logan popped his claws. *SNIKT.*

"Let's go," he said.

CHAPTER 19: THE POLITICS OF ETERNITY

LOCATION: TVA HEADQUARTERS (MAIN TIMELINE)

Side Story G: The Dissent

Hunter B-15 walked down the corridor.

The TVA was designed to be timeless. No clocks. No windows. Just the endless, low hum of bureaucracy. But today, the hum was different. It was frantic.

"Sector 4 is reporting fluctuations," Analyst Kevin said, running to keep up with her. "The Time Ripper is drawing power from the main loom. It's unstable."

"Where is Paradox?" B-15 asked.

"He's at the Outpost. In the Void."

B-15 stopped. She turned to Kevin.

"The Void is a dumping ground," she said. "It's not a power station. What is he doing?"

Kevin looked nervous. He adjusted his glasses.

"He... he says he's conducting a 'radical pruning'. He says the timeline is sick. He says mercy is inefficient."

B-15 felt a cold knot in her stomach.

She remembered the old TVA. The one ruled by the Time Keepers. The one that pruned without question. They had fought to change that. They had fought to let the branches grow.

And now Paradox was trying to bring back the shears.

"He's not pruning," B-15 said. "He's murdering. He's killing a timeline because he doesn't like the ending."

She tapped her TempPad.

"Open a channel to the Outpost," she ordered.

"It's blocked, Ma'am. Paradox has locked the frequency."

B-15 looked at the wall monitor. It showed the Sacred Timeline. A beautiful, glowing rope of light.

But there was a dark spot. A rot. Spreading from Earth-10005.

"He's going to kill them all," Kevin whispered.

"Not if we stop him," B-15 said. "Assemble the Minutemen. The *loyal* ones."

"Ma'am? That's treason."

"No," B-15 said. "That's leadership."

She drew her baton. It glowed purple.

"Let's go save a universe."

CHAPTER 20: THE UNZIPPING

****LOCATION: THE TIME RIPPER CHAMBER****

The sound was the first thing.

It wasn't a mechanical noise. It wasn't gears grinding or turbines spinning.

It was the sound of screaming.

But not human screaming. It was the sound of *reality* screaming. It was the sound of atoms being torn apart, of history being ripped from the textbook pages.

SKREEEEEEEEEEEEEEEE.

I fell to my knees. My ears bled. Not metaphorically. Warm, wet blood trickled down my neck.

"Wade!" Logan yelled.

He was fighting Cassandra. She was floating in the center of the room, her hands deep in the machine. She looked ecstatic. She looked like a conductor leading an orchestra of apocalypse.

"It's beautiful!" Cassandra laughed. "Can you feel it? The silence coming?"

The room was distorting. The walls were stretching like taffy. Colors were bleeding into each other. Orange became purple. Up became sideways.

Sensory Overload:

* **Sight:** The air rippled like heat haze on asphalt. I saw my own hand age, wither to bone, then regenerate, then turn into a baby hand.

* **Smell:** Burning film stock. Celluloid on fire. The chemical tang of developer fluid.

* **Taste:** Ash. I tasted the ash of a billion lives.

"Stop it!" I yelled.

I charged.

Cassandra flicked a finger.

I flew backward. I hit a console. *CRACK.* My spine snapped.

"You can't stop the ending," Cassandra said. "The credits are rolling."

She plunged her hands deeper. The beam intensified.

The screen on the wall showed my world.

I saw Blind Al. She was fading. Turning into static.

I saw Peter. He was holding Muffin. He looked confused. Then he was gone.

I saw Vanessa.

She was walking down the street. She looked up. She saw the sky turning purple.

She didn't run. She didn't scream. She just looked... sad.

No.

"LOGAN!" I screamed.

Logan looked at the screen. He saw it too.

He saw the X-Men. Not his X-Men. *My* X-Men. Colossus. Negasonic. Yukio.

They were holding hands. Bracing for the end.

Logan roared.

It wasn't a battle cry. It was a sound of pure, distilled grief.

He launched himself at Cassandra.

She tried to push him back. But he was heavy. He was the Anchor. He was density incarnate.

He slammed into her.

They crashed into the energy stream.

FZZEEEEEEEEEE.

The room exploded in light.

CHAPTER 21: THE CHOICE

I was floating.

White space. No floor. No ceiling.

Paradox stood there.

"Mr. Wilson," he said. He looked calm. Clean.

"Am I dead?" I asked. "Is this the lobby? Do you have magazines?"

"You are at the decision point," Paradox said. "The fulcrum."

He gestured.

Two doors appeared.

Door A: A golden door. Light spilled from it.

Door B: A wooden door. Rotting.

"Behind Door A," Paradox said, "is the Sacred Timeline. You join the Avengers. You become a legend. You matter. But your world dies. Your friends die."

"And Door B?"

"Door B is the hard way," Paradox said. "You go back. You fight. You probably die. And even if you win... you're just Wade Wilson. A clown in a red suit."

I looked at Door A.

I saw it. I saw me shaking hands with Thor. I saw me on a lunchbox. I saw me being *happy*.

I looked at Door B.

I saw the pain. The mess. The struggle.

I saw Vanessa.

"It's not a choice," I said.

"Of course it is," Paradox argued. "It's the only choice that matters. Self or Sacrifice."

"No," I said. "It's not a choice because I've already made it."

I walked to Door B.

"Hey, Paradox?"

"Yes?"

"Tell Thor to save his tears. I don't need them."

I kicked the door open.

****REALITY****

I woke up screaming.

I was in the chamber. The energy was tearing me apart. My skin was peeling off in strips. My muscles were cooking.

Logan was next to me. He was burning too. His skin was gone. He was a skeleton dipped in lava.

"WADE!" he screamed.

We were holding the cables. We were the circuit. We were grounding the power.

"Let go!" Cassandra shrieked. "You'll die!"

"That's the plan!" I yelled.

I looked at Logan.

He looked at me.

His eyes—the only part of him that wasn't burning—were clear.

"Maximum Effort?" he asked.

It was my line. He stole my line.

I laughed. My lips cracked and fell off.

"Maximum Effort."

We squeezed the cables.

BOOM.

The world went white.

And then... silence.

CHAPTER 22: EPILOGUE

****LOCATION: NEW YORK CITY (EARTH-10005)****

****TIME: THREE DAYS LATER****

The shawarma tasted like victory.

And garlic. Mostly garlic.

We sat on the curb. Me. Logan. Laura.

It was raining, but it was a nice rain. A cleansing rain.

Logan was eating a gyro with a ferocity that was frankly alarming. He ate like a man who had forgotten what food tasted like.

"Slow down, peanut," I said. "You'll get indigestion. And I don't want to be around for **that** biological event."

Logan grunted. He wiped sauce from his beard.

"It's good," he said.

"It's the best," I agreed.

I looked at Laura. She was wearing sunglasses. She looked cool.

"So," I said. "What now?"

"Now we live," Laura said.

"Living is hard," I noted. "Dying is easy. Comedy is hard. But living? Living is just... laundry and taxes."

"And family," Logan said.

He didn't look at me. He looked at the street. But I heard it.

Family.

"Yeah," I said. "And family."

Blind Al opened the window above us.

"Keep it down!" she yelled. "I'm listening to a podcast about serial killers! It's soothing!"

"Love you too, Al!" I shouted back.

I looked at my watch. Hello Kitty was still ticking.

I had a date. Vanessa was waiting.

"I gotta go," I said. "Don't wait up. Don't touch my stuff. Don't prune the plants."

I stood up.

"Wade," Logan said.

I turned.

"See you around, Bub."

It wasn't a threat. It was a promise.

I smiled.

"See you around, peanut."

I walked away.

The city was loud. Sirens. Honking. People yelling.

It was chaotic. It was messy. It was beautiful.

It was my world.

And it was still here.

Fade to black.

Cue music.

Madonna. 'Like a Prayer'.

Because obviously.

THE END.

POST-CREDITS ARTIFACT

TVA MEMO: 999-Z

FROM: B-15

TO: ALL AGENTS

SUBJECT: RE: DEADPOOL & WOLVERINE

STATUS: CASE CLOSED.

NOTE: The timeline Earth-10005 is stable. The Anchor Being has been... substituted. Or shared. The physics are unclear.

ACTION: Do not approach. Do not engage. Do not prune.

Let them be.

They earned it.
